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Governments of the Republic of Korea, Japan, the People's Republic of China, the United Kingdom, the United States, France and Germany, with the French Parliament and Senate, the German Bundestag, INSEE and the public banks Bpifrance, the Japan Finance Corporation and KfW

Summary: This report reviews the inclusive entrepreneurship policy that the governments of Korea, Japan, China, the United Kingdom, the United States, France and Germany set out from January to December 2022 for women, young and older people, immigrants, persons with disabilities, the unemployed, rural people, minorities, veterans and the smallest self-employed, in six domains, and analyses it in its context, against theory and in practice. Law moved mostly for the smallest self-employed, finance relieved debt and widened guaranteed credit, and culture was addressed by weeks, recognition and statistics. The best measures gave sole proprietors a protected estate and individual businesses equal treatment, widened credit through US state credit plans, and supported founders in deprived places; the worst left public markets without any measure for the groups. Some instruments for women founders were only announced or planned, persons with disabilities and older people were the least served, and implementation was reported as outputs.

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Inclusive Entrepreneurship Policy in Korea, Japan, China, the United Kingdom, the United States, France and Germany, 2022

IFEED Institute for Entrepreneurial Ecosystem Development

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Inclusive Entrepreneurship Policy in Korea, Japan, China, the United Kingdom, the United States, France and Germany, 2022

Abstract

This report reviews and analyses the inclusive entrepreneurship policy of the governments of the Republic of Korea, Japan, the People's Republic of China, the United Kingdom, the United States, France and Germany in their own plans, laws, budgets and announcements: the measures that supported, or withdrew support from, entrepreneurship by women, young and older people, immigrants, persons with disabilities, the unemployed, rural people, minorities, veterans and the smallest self-employed. The policies are reviewed in six domains — regulation and law, finance, culture, support, human capital and markets — and analysed in their context, against theories of problem representation, target populations, business failure, credit constraints and immigrant entrepreneurship, and in practice. Law moved mostly for the smallest self-employed: France gave sole proprietors a separate professional estate and opened the self-employed workers' allowance to owners of failed businesses, China's regulation on individual businesses took effect in November, and Korea passed accident insurance for labour providers from July 2023, while Germany's insurance of the self-employed remained a promise. Finance relieved debt and widened credit: Korea opened a fund to restructure the debts of the self-employed, China offered guaranteed loans to graduates, and the United States approved state credit plans. The United Kingdom closed its allowance for claimants starting a business and reversed its announced repeal of the off-payroll rules. Instruments for women founders, such as Germany's fund instrument and Korea's fund allocation for women's firms, were only announced or planned, persons with disabilities and older people were the least served, routes for foreign founders widened only in small steps, and implementation was reported as outputs rather than as who was reached. The period covered is January to December 2022.

Keywords

inclusive entrepreneurship, self-employment, sole proprietors, individual businesses, women entrepreneurs, immigrant founders, entrepreneurs with disabilities, debt relief, guaranteed loans, social insurance, procurement preferences

JEL Classification

L26, J16, J15, J68, H81, R58

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1 INTRODUCTION

Key findings

- Law moved mostly for the smallest self-employed in France, China and Korea, while Japan's freelance law and Germany's insurance of the self-employed remained promises.
- Finance relieved debt and widened credit through Korea's New Start Fund, China's guaranteed loans for graduates and US state credit plans.
- Women were counted more than they were reached, at 41 % of creators of sole proprietorships in France and 19 % of start-up founders in Germany.
- Support was also withdrawn: the United Kingdom closed its allowance for claimants starting a business and reversed its repeal of the off-payroll rules.
- Routes for foreign founders widened in small steps in Japan and the United Kingdom.
- Persons with disabilities and older people were the least served.
- Implementation was reported as outputs rather than as who was reached.

Inclusive entrepreneurship policy supports, or withdraws support from, entrepreneurship by under-represented or disadvantaged people. Problem definitions, it has been argued, leave questions unsaid (Bacchi, 2009) and construct target groups as deserving or not (Schneider & Ingram, 1993). The report asks (1) what policies each country set out in each domain in 2022, (2) how they arose, how valid they were in theory and what they achieved, and (3) what their limitations were and what follows for policy. It draws on evidence on credit (Blanchflower & Oswald, 1998), failure (Armour & Cumming, 2008) and the barriers of particular groups (Ahl & Nelson, 2015; Renko, Parker Harris, & Caldwell, 2016). Section 2 reviews the policies, Section 3 analyses them, and Sections 4 and 5 set out their limits and implications. The report rests on the governments' own plans, laws, budgets, reports and announcements (Table 1); quotations from sources not in English are IFEED's translations.

Table 1: Government plans, laws, reports and announcements reviewed

Subject	Issuing bodies	Date and type	Period covered	Description
Korea				
Accident insurance act	MOEL	29 May 2022 Press release	May 2022	Labour providers covered.
Middle-aged centres	MSS	7 June 2022 Press release	June 2022	Centres; boot camp.
Small business policy	MSS	25 August 2022 Press release	August 2022	New government's direction.
New Start Fund launch	FSC	23 September 2022 Press release	October 2022	Fund opened on 4 October.
Women Venture Week	MSS	9 November 2022 Press release	2018-2022	Fund; women's programme.

Subject	Issuing bodies	Date and type	Period covered	Description
Purchase convention	MSS	24 November 2022 Press release	November 2022	Statutory purchase ratios.
Small business notice	MSS	28 December 2022 Press release	December 2022	Fast track for indebted owners.
Japan				
Women's priority policy	Cabinet headquarters	3 June 2022 Priority policy	2022	Bonus points in procurement.
Action plan	Cabinet	7 June 2022 Cabinet decision	2022	Freelancers.
Disability white paper	Cabinet Office	June 2022 White paper	2021–2022	Disabled founders.
JFC loans, first half	JFC	15 November 2022 News release	April–September 2022	Loans to women before founding.
Start-up five-year plan	New capitalism council	28 November 2022 Plan	November 2022	Visa; guarantees.
Special-zone guideline	Immigration agency	December 2022 Guidelines	December 2022	Co-working premises.
China				
Disabled employment	State Council office	25 March 2022 Action plan	2022	Platforms; training.
Young people	State Council office	5 May 2022 Notice	2022	Loans; anti-discrimination.
Stabilising the economy	State Council	24 May 2022 Notice	2022	Deferral; procurement; new residents.
Individual businesses	State Council	1 October 2022 Regulation	November 2022	Order No. 755.
United Kingdom				
Immigration rules	Home Office	15 March 2022 Memorandum	March–April 2022	Innovator route.
Inclusive Britain	Race Disparity Unit; DLUHC	17 March 2022 Action plan	2012–2022	Ethnic minority entrepreneurs.
Procurement Bill	Cabinet Office	12 May 2022 News story	May 2022	Duties towards SMEs.
Access to Work	DWP	24 May 2022 Written answer	May 2022	Disabled freelancers.
New Enterprise Allowance	DWP	15 June 2022 Statistics	2011–2021	Closure; participants.
Investing in Women Code	BEIS	28 June 2022 Press release	2021–2022	Deals with women founders.
Autumn Statement	HM Treasury	17 November 2022 Fiscal statement	November 2022	Reversals; threshold freeze.
United States				
Equitable recovery	SBA	21 January 2022 Press release	2021–2022	Centres; navigators.
SBA budget request	SBA	28 March 2022 Budget request	2020–2022	Contracting results.

Subject	Issuing bodies	Date and type	Period covered	Description
Small Business Week	President	29 April 2022 Proclamation	May 2022	Contracting pledge.
State credit initiative	Treasury	19 May 2022 Press release	May 2022	First state plans.
Mission lenders	SBA	7 November 2022 Proposed rule	November–December 2022	Moratorium to end.
Veteran certification	SBA	29 November 2022 Final rule	November–December 2022	Certification from 2023.
France				
Business creations 2021	INSEE	2 February 2022 Statistics	2015–2021	Creators by sex and age.
Bpifrance in 2021	Bpifrance	3 February 2022 Press release	2021	Honour loans; micro-credit.
Independent-worker act	Parliament	14 February 2022 Act	February–September 2022	Act No. 2022-172.
Rebound conference	MEFR	16 February 2022 Press release	February 2022	Failure; rebound portal.
French Tech Springboard	MEFIDS	15 September 2022 Press release	2020–2022	Third edition; survey.
Senate budget reports	Senate	17 November 2022 Budget reports	2022	Zones; employment measures.
Germany				
Covid aid overview	Federal Government	4 January 2022 Overview	2021–2022	Aid paid; basic income.
Annual economic report	Federal Government	26 January 2022 Report	2022	Social protection plans.
Bridging aid extended	Federal Government	1 April 2022 News article	April–June 2022	Aid to end-June.
Start-up Strategy	Federal Government	28 July 2022 Strategy	July 2022	Women; migrants; regions.
Citizen's income bill	Federal Government	10 October 2022 Bill	October 2022	Savings of the self-employed.
Female entrepreneurship	KfW Research	14 November 2022 Study and release	2017–2021	Stereotypes; venture deals.
Citizen's income decision	Bundestag	25 November 2022 Decision	November 2022	Conciliation result adopted.

Source: The plans, laws, reports and announcements listed. Periods covered and descriptions: IFEED.

Note: Where a source has several parts, citations name the part (for example, plan or press release) before the page. Abbreviations: BEIS, Department for Business, Energy and Industrial Strategy; COVID-19, coronavirus disease 2019; DLUHC, Department for Levelling Up, Housing and Communities; DWP, Department for Work and Pensions; EXIST, Business Start-ups from Science (federal programme); FSC, Financial Services Commission; HC, House of Commons paper; HM, Her or His Majesty's; INSEE, National Institute of Statistics and Economic Studies; IPO, initial public offering; JFC, Japan Finance Corporation; KfW, Germany's federal promotional bank; MEFIDS, Ministry of the Economy, Finance and Industrial and Digital Sovereignty; MEFR, Ministry of the Economy, Finance and Recovery; MOEL, Ministry of Employment and Labor; MSS, Ministry of SMEs and Startups; SBA, U.S. Small Business Administration; SME, small and medium-sized enterprise; UK, United Kingdom; US, United States.

2 REVIEW OF INCLUSIVE ENTREPRENEURSHIP POLICIES

This section reviews the key policies of 2022 in six domains of the entrepreneurial ecosystem: regulation and law, finance, culture, support, human capital and markets.

2.1 REGULATION AND LAW

Law moved mostly for the smallest self-employed, while a freelance law and insurance of the self-employed remained promises.

2.1.1 KOREA: ACCIDENT INSURANCE AND THE OWNER DEFINITION

On 29 May the National Assembly passed an amendment extending accident insurance to special-type and platform workers from 1 July 2023 (MOEL, 29 May 2022, p. 2), while defining small business owners by turnover alone was planned (MSS, 25 August 2022, p. 3). This was a mixed policy: the insurance will protect labour providers, but the turnover definition was a plan.

2.1.2 JAPAN: THE PLANNED FREELANCE LAW AND THE RE-CHALLENGE RULE

The Cabinet's action plan of 7 June counted 4.62 million freelancers and promised a law on fair transactions with them (Cabinet of Japan, 7 June 2022, p. 17), but no bill was submitted in 2022, and the Start-up Development Five-year Plan of 28 November reported a 2022 amendment that protects the unemployment benefit claims of people who try a business, from a date it did not state (Council for the Realisation of a New Form of Capitalism, 28 November 2022, p. 9). This was a mixed policy: the re-challenge rule, once applied, lowers the cost of failure, but its start was not stated and the freelance law was a promise.

2.1.3 CHINA: REGULATION ON INDIVIDUAL BUSINESSES (ORDER NO. 755)

The State Council's Regulation on individual businesses, in force from 1 November, bars discrimination against them in licensing and procurement and forbids forcing workers to register as such (State Council of the People's Republic of China, 1 October 2022, Arts. 5, 16, 30, 39). This was a good policy: it is in force and protects the smallest firms, though no measure for women, minority, older or foreign founders appears in the State Council policy library for 2022.

2.1.4 UNITED KINGDOM: THE PROFITS LIMIT AND OFF-PAYROLL RULES

The Lower Profits Limit rose to GBP 12,570 from July and is to stay there for five years from April 2023 (HM Treasury, 17 November 2022, para. 5.17); the off-payroll repeal announced in the Growth Plan of September was reversed in the Autumn Statement of 17 November (HM Treasury, 17 November 2022, table 5.2). This was a mixed policy: the higher limit helps low earners, but it is to be frozen as prices rise, and the repeal was withdrawn within two months.

2.1.5 UNITED STATES: VETERAN CERTIFICATION AND MISSION LENDERS

Under a final rule of 29 November the SBA will certify veteran-owned small businesses from 1 January 2023 (SBA, 29 November 2022, pp. 73400, 73405), while letting new nonprofit lending

companies into SBA lending was only proposed (SBA, 7 November 2022, pp. 66963–66964). This was a mixed policy: certification will give veterans one status, but the opening to nonprofit lenders was a proposal.

2.1.6 FRANCE: ACT NO. 2022-172 ON INDEPENDENT PROFESSIONAL ACTIVITY

Act No. 2022-172 of 14 February separates the professional and personal estates of sole proprietors from mid-May and opens the self-employed workers' allowance to owners of businesses closed as not viable (Parliament of France, 14 February 2022, Arts. 1, 5, 11, 19). This was a good policy: both are in force and lower the cost of failure, as more forgiving bankruptcy law has been found to go with higher self-employment (Armour & Cumming, 2008).

2.1.7 GERMANY: SELF-EMPLOYED INSURANCE AND THE CITIZEN'S INCOME BILL

The Annual Economic Report of 26 January announced easier voluntary unemployment insurance and a duty of old-age provision for new self-employed people without cover (Federal Government of Germany, 26 January 2022, p. 78), but no bill followed in 2022; simplified access to basic income support for them was extended to 31 March (Federal Government of Germany, 4 January 2022, p. 2), and the Citizen's Income bill, whose conciliation form the Bundestag adopted on 25 November (German Bundestag, 25 November 2022, decision), will leave their old-age savings out of the asset test from 1 January 2023 (Federal Government of Germany, 10 October 2022, pp. 16, 45). This was a mixed policy: basic income support kept a safety net in the first quarter and the bill will protect their old-age savings, but their insurance remained an announcement.

2.2 FINANCE: GRANTS, FUNDING AND FINANCIAL INFRASTRUCTURE

Finance worked through debt relief, public lenders and guaranteed loans, but some instruments for women founders were only announced or planned.

2.2.1 KOREA: THE NEW START FUND AND THE FUND ALLOCATION FOR WOMEN

The FSC's New Start Fund opened on 4 October to write off 60 % to 80 % of the net debt in default of small business owners hit by COVID-19, and possibly more for severely disabled people and low-income people aged 70 or over (FSC, 23 September 2022, pp. 1–2, 5, 9); the guarantee for women-owned firms had guaranteed KRW 2.7659 trillion in 2018 to 2022, and a larger fund allocation for women's firms was planned (MSS, 9 November 2022, pp. 1–2). This was a mixed policy: the fund lowers the cost of failure but relieves debt rather than financing founding, and while the guarantee eases women's access to credit, the allocation was a plan.

2.2.2 JAPAN: JFC START-UP LOANS AND THE PLANNED GUARANTEE REFORM

From April to September the JFC's loans before founding to 2,219 women stood at 108.1 % of the same period of fiscal year 2019 (JFC, 15 November 2022, table 2), while guarantee-free start-up loans were planned (Council for the Realisation of a New Form of Capitalism, 28 November 2022, p. 15). This was a mixed policy: the JFC lends to women, but the guarantee reform was a plan.

2.2.3 CHINA: GUARANTEED START-UP LOANS AND THE LOAN DEFERRAL REQUEST

Guaranteed loans were offered to graduates (General Office of the State Council of the People's Republic of China, 5 May 2022, item 3), while loan deferral was requested and new urban residents were promised such loans (State Council of the People's Republic of China, 24 May 2022, measures 8, 32). This was a mixed policy: the loans relax the credit constraint of people without wealth (Blanchflower & Oswald, 1998), but the deferral was a request, the extension an announcement, and take-up was not reported.

2.2.4 UNITED KINGDOM: THE INVESTING IN WOMEN CODE

Under the voluntary Investing in Women Code, 34 % of signatories' venture capital deals in 2021 were in companies with a female founder, against 24 % across the industry (BEIS, 28 June 2022, release), and an ethnicity data pilot was promised (Race Disparity Unit & DLUHC, 17 March 2022, p. 80). This was a mixed policy: the Code acts on investors, as the evidence on investor bias supports (Ewens & Townsend, 2020), but it is voluntary, the pilot was an announcement, and no finance was aimed at disabled, older or immigrant founders.

2.2.5 UNITED STATES: THE STATE SMALL BUSINESS CREDIT INITIATIVE

On 19 May the Treasury approved state plans under the State Small Business Credit Initiative, with USD 1 billion of incentives for reaching the underserved, and Maryland expected 70 % of its new loans to go to minority-owned and 40 % to women-owned businesses (U.S. Department of the Treasury, 19 May 2022, release). This was a good policy: the plans ease the credit constraint of founders without wealth (Blanchflower & Oswald, 1998) and reward reaching the underserved.

2.2.6 FRANCE: HONOUR LOANS AND THE ENTREPRENEURS' REBOUND PORTAL

Bpifrance reported more than 8,000 honour loans to creators and more than 36,000 guaranteed professional micro-credits in 2021 (Bpifrance, 3 February 2022, release), and the State announced more support for the Entrepreneurs' Rebound Portal without an amount (MEFR, 16 February 2022, release). This was a mixed policy: honour loans reached creators, but support for owners who fail was promised without a sum.

2.2.7 GERMANY: THE RESTART AID AND INSTRUMENTS FOR WOMEN FOUNDERS

The restart aid for solo self-employed people ran unchanged to June (Federal Government of Germany, 1 April 2022, article), while a Future Fund instrument for women founders and diverse venture capital teams and an EXIST Women line were announced without amounts (Federal Government of Germany, 28 July 2022, p. 10). This was a mixed policy: the aid helped the solo self-employed, but the women's instruments were only announced.

2.3 CULTURE

Culture was addressed by weeks, recognition and statistics, which showed women well below half of founders wherever they were counted.

2.3.1 KOREA: WOMEN VENTURE WEEK

The third Women Venture Week, on 9 November, honoured women-led ventures; technology start-ups by women had risen by 6.8 % in a year against 3.1 % for men (MSS, 9 November 2022, p. 1). This was a mixed policy: ventures were counted by sex, but the week honours founders without changing the institutions they meet (Ahl & Nelson, 2015).

2.3.2 JAPAN: THE JFC CONSULTATION WEEK FOR WOMEN AND YOUNG PEOPLE

The JFC held its 11th consultation week for women and young people in November and December and reported its loans by sex (JFC, 15 November 2022, p. 2 and table 2). This was a mixed policy: the JFC counts loans by sex, but the week works on founders, not lenders (Ahl & Nelson, 2015).

2.3.3 CHINA: MODEL INDIVIDUAL BUSINESSES AND A PUBLICITY YEAR

The Regulation asks governments to reward model individual businesses (State Council of the People's Republic of China, 1 October 2022, Art. 29), and 2022 was a publicity year for disabled people's employment (General Office of the State Council of the People's Republic of China, 25 March 2022, Part III, item 5). This was a mixed policy: recognition is in force, but the publicity year concerns jobs.

2.3.4 UNITED KINGDOM: ALLOWANCE STATISTICS AND THE TASKFORCE

The New Enterprise Allowance's statistics showed 42 % of its starters to have been women and about 63,000 to have had a disability (DWP, 15 June 2022, main text), and a taskforce for women-led growth firms was to influence investors (BEIS, 28 June 2022, release). This was a mixed policy: the statistics count participants by group, but the taskforce only convenes investors.

2.3.5 UNITED STATES: SMALL BUSINESS WEEK AND OWNER DATA

A presidential proclamation cited more women and minorities starting enterprises (President of the United States, 29 April 2022, p. 26668), and the SBA reported contracting by owner group against goals (SBA, 28 March 2022, performance report, pp. 63–64, 76). This was a mixed policy: the reporting counts reach by group, but the proclamation brought no new measures.

2.3.6 FRANCE: THE REBOUND CONFERENCE AND INSEE'S COUNT OF CREATORS

The Entrepreneurs' Rebound Conference of 15 February addressed attitudes to failure (MEFR, 16 February 2022, release), and INSEE found that women created 41 % of new sole proprietorships in 2021, little changed since 2015 (INSEE, 2 February 2022, section on women). This was a mixed policy: INSEE counts creators by sex and the conference addresses the stigma of failure, but women's flat share met no measure.

2.3.7 GERMANY: THE ROLE-MODEL INITIATIVE AND THE KFW STUDY OF WOMEN

KfW found women at 19 % of start-up founders on average in 2017–2021 (KfW Research, 14 November 2022, p. 3), and the Start-up Strategy promised to strengthen a role-model initiative for women (Federal Government of Germany, 28 July 2022, p. 10). This was a mixed policy: KfW counts founders by sex, but the promised initiative works on women, not investors (Ahl & Nelson, 2015).

2.4 SUPPORT: INSTITUTIONAL SUPPORT

Support reached women, older founders and deprived places, but one route for the unemployed closed and few programmes reached persons with disabilities.

2.4.1 KOREA: MIDDLE-AGED START-UP CENTRES AND THE FAST TRACK

There were 35 middle-aged technology start-up centres (MSS, 7 June 2022, p. 1) and a women venture start-up care programme (MSS, 9 November 2022, p. 2), while a fast track for indebted owners was announced (MSS, 28 December 2022, release). This was a mixed policy: the centres and the programme reach older and women founders, but the fast track was an announcement.

2.4.2 JAPAN: WELFARE LOANS FOR DISABLED FOUNDERS

For disabled founders the white paper reported welfare-fund loans for a livelihood business and general start-up support (Cabinet Office of Japan, June 2022, section 2 (5)). This was a mixed policy: the welfare loan is in place, but other support was general, although disabled founders less often reach a viable firm (Renko et al., 2016).

2.4.3 CHINA: FREE START-UP SPACE AND PLATFORM FEES

Government-built start-up space was to offer about 30 % of places free to graduates (General Office of the State Council of the People's Republic of China, 5 May 2022, item 3), and platforms were asked to cut fees for disabled founders (General Office of the State Council of the People's Republic of China, 25 March 2022, action 3). This was a mixed policy: the space serves graduates, but the fee cuts were a request.

2.4.4 UNITED KINGDOM: THE NEW ENTERPRISE ALLOWANCE AND ACCESS TO WORK

The New Enterprise Allowance, which had helped claimants set up 161,000 businesses, closed to new participants on 1 January (DWP, 15 June 2022, main text, sections 1–2), the Enterprise Strategy promised in Inclusive Britain (Race Disparity Unit & DLUHC, 17 March 2022, pp. 81–82) was not published in 2022, and Access to Work had introduced a flexible application for disabled freelancers (DWP, 24 May 2022, answer). This was a mixed policy: the flexible application reaches disabled freelancers, but the closure cut a route into self-employment.

2.4.5 UNITED STATES: WOMEN'S BUSINESS CENTERS AND NAVIGATORS

By January the SBA had 140 Women's Business Centers, 22 Veterans Business Outreach Centers and a Community Navigator Pilot (SBA, 21 January 2022, release), while technical assistance was planned (U.S. Department of the Treasury, 19 May 2022, release). This was a mixed policy: the centres reach women, veterans and the underserved, but the assistance was a plan, and no programme named older founders, or disabled founders other than veterans.

2.4.6 FRANCE: THE FRENCH TECH SPRINGBOARD PROGRAMME

The French Tech Springboard serves people on social minima, scholarship holders, refugees and residents of priority neighbourhoods or rural revitalisation zones; a third cohort of 434 was to begin in mid-October, and 93 % of surveyed first winners' start-ups were active (MEFIDS, 15

September 2022, release). This was a good policy: it is running and targets need and place, a construction that, it has been argued, shapes who benefits (Schneider & Ingram, 1993), although survival was reported for one cohort only.

2.4.7 GERMANY: THE FORUM FOR MIGRANT FOUNDERS AND EXIST

The Start-up Strategy announced a forum for migrant founders and said its measures, EXIST among them, also served structurally weak regions (Federal Government of Germany, 28 July 2022, pp. 9–10). This was a mixed policy: EXIST, a running programme, reaches weak regions, but the forum was announced and no running support programme targeted women, disabled or older founders.

2.5 HUMAN CAPITAL: EDUCATION AND TRAINING, AND LABOUR

Human capital measures mostly prepared people for employment, while routes for foreign founders widened in small steps.

2.5.1 KOREA: FIELD TRAINING AND THE MIDDLE-AGED BOOT CAMP

The government promised field training for about 20,000 prospective owners a year (MSS, 25 August 2022, p. 3), and a start-up boot camp lets middle-aged employees prepare a start-up before retirement (MSS, 7 June 2022, p. 1). This was a mixed policy: the boot camp prepares older employees for founding, but field training at scale was a plan.

2.5.2 JAPAN: THE START-UP VISA PLAN AND THE SPECIAL-ZONE GUIDELINE

The Start-up Plan promised to let private bodies confirm start-up visa founders (Council for the Realisation of a New Form of Capitalism, 28 November 2022, p. 9), and a December guideline lets foreign founders in special zones use co-working offices as premises (Immigration Services Agency of Japan, December 2022, pp. 2–3). This was a mixed policy: the guideline helps foreign founders, and immigrants who came to study or work start companies more often than natives with similar education (Hunt, 2011), but the private-body route was a plan.

2.5.3 CHINA: GRADUATE RECRUITMENT RULES AND DISABILITY TRAINING

Discrimination by sex, age and education in graduates' employment was to be prevented (General Office of the State Council of the People's Republic of China, 5 May 2022, item 9), and disabled people were offered entrepreneurship training with subsidies (General Office of the State Council of the People's Republic of China, 25 March 2022, action 10). This was a mixed policy: the training reaches disabled people, but most measures prepared people for employment.

2.5.4 UNITED KINGDOM: THE INNOVATOR ROUTE AND WORKERS OVER 50

Under rules implemented on dates from 6 April, Innovator founders who miss settlement requirements may be granted permission to stay (Home Office, 15 March 2022, paras. 6.4, 7.45), and a review of workforce participation among people over 50 was announced (HM Treasury, 17 November 2022, paras. 3.6–3.7). This was a mixed policy: the Innovator change keeps founders in

the country, but the review concerns employment, although activity in self-employment rises with age among those who prefer it (Kautonen, Down, & Minniti, 2014).

2.5.5 UNITED STATES: SBA RESOURCE PARTNERS

The SBA's resource partners trained or advised over 1 million entrepreneurs in fiscal year 2021, its Women's Business Centers nearly 88,000 (SBA, 28 March 2022, performance report, pp. 79, 83). This was a mixed policy: the centres reach women, but most training was general.

2.5.6 FRANCE: TRAINING OF THE SELF-EMPLOYED AND THE YOUTH CONTRACT

Training reform for the self-employed applied from 1 September (Parliament of France, 14 February 2022, Arts. 12, 19), while youth engagement contracts neared 200,000 by September (Finance Committee of the Senate of France, 17 November 2022, labour report). This was a mixed policy: the training reform is in force, but the largest youth measure aimed at employment.

2.5.7 GERMANY: THE START-UP GRANT AND JUNIOR SCHOOL COMPANIES

The Start-up Strategy described the start-up grant for unemployed founders without a change, wanted start-ups to sponsor junior school companies (Federal Government of Germany, 28 July 2022, p. 9) and aimed at faster visas for skilled workers (Federal Government of Germany, 28 July 2022, p. 7). This was a mixed policy: the grant's effects for the unemployed have been found lasting (Caliendo & Künn, 2011), but no results were reported, the school companies were an intention and the visa process served skilled workers rather than founders.

2.6 MARKET: MARKET AND INDUSTRY SUPPORT, IPO AND EXIT

Market measures were mostly procurement preferences and place-based tax relief for firms of certain owners or places, not for founders from the groups.

2.6.1 KOREA: PURCHASE RATIOS FOR WOMEN- AND DISABLED-OWNED FIRMS

On 24 November the MSS restated the purchase ratios of public bodies: at least 5 % of goods and services and 3 % of construction from women-owned firms, and at least 1 % of all purchases from disabled-owned firms (MSS, 24 November 2022, p. 1); e-commerce training for owners was planned (MSS, 25 August 2022, p. 3). This was a mixed policy: the ratios reserve demand for these firms, but whether they were met is not shown, and the training was a plan.

2.6.2 JAPAN: BONUS POINTS IN PUBLIC PROCUREMENT

National bodies award extra procurement points to firms certified under the Act on Promotion of Women's Participation (Headquarters for Creating a Society in Which All Women Shine & Headquarters for the Promotion of Gender Equality, 3 June 2022, p. 19). This was a mixed policy: the points reward employers that advance women rather than women-owned firms.

2.6.3 CHINA: EQUAL TREATMENT AND SMALL-FIRM PREFERENCES IN PROCUREMENT

The Regulation bars discrimination against individual businesses in procurement and bidding (State Council of the People's Republic of China, 1 October 2022, Arts. 5, 16), and the State Council

decided to raise the price deduction for small and micro firms in government procurement to 10 % to 20 % and, for 2022, the share of works procurement reserved for SMEs to over 40 % (State Council of the People's Republic of China, 24 May 2022, measure 5). This was a mixed policy: the ban is in force for individual businesses, but the preferences serve small firms in general rather than founders from the groups.

2.6.4 UNITED KINGDOM: THE PROCUREMENT BILL

The Procurement Bill, set out by the Cabinet Office on 12 May, would require contracting authorities to consider SMEs, extend 30-day payment terms and let buyers reserve some competitions for SMEs (Cabinet Office of the United Kingdom, 12 May 2022, news story). This was a poor policy: the bill was not law and was for small firms in general, with no supplier-diversity rule.

2.6.5 UNITED STATES: CONTRACTING GOALS FOR DISADVANTAGED FIRMS

In fiscal year 2020 federal contracting met its goals for service-disabled veteran-owned firms (4.3 % against 3 %) and disadvantaged businesses (10.5 % against 5 %) but not for women-owned firms (4.8 %, 4.9 % in its table, against 5 %), and the disadvantaged goal rose to 11 % for fiscal year 2022 (SBA, 28 March 2022, performance report, pp. 63–64, 76); the President restated a pledge to raise contracting with underserved businesses (President of the United States, 29 April 2022, p. 26667). This was a mixed policy: two goals were met, but the women's goal was missed and the further increase was a pledge.

2.6.6 FRANCE: URBAN FREE ZONES AND RURAL REVITALISATION ZONES

Firms in the 100 urban free zones are exempt from tax on profits for eight years under conditions, and the rural revitalisation zone exemptions had been prolonged to 31 December 2023 pending reform (Finance Committee of the Senate of France, 17 November 2022, city policy report, programme 147, and regional policy synthesis, pp. 3–4). This was a mixed policy: the exemptions are in force but serve places rather than founders from the groups.

2.6.7 GERMANY: PUBLIC CONTRACTS FOR START-UPS AND YOUNG FIRMS

The Annual Economic Report planned easier access to public contracts for start-ups and young firms (Federal Government of Germany, 26 January 2022, p. 68), and KfW reported that 83 % of German venture capital deals went to all-male teams (KfW Research, 14 November 2022, press release). This was a poor policy: the procurement measure was an intention for start-ups in general, and no measure opened public markets to women, migrant or disabled founders.

3 ANALYSIS OF THE POLICIES

3.1 CONTEXTUAL ANALYSIS: ORIGINS, BACKGROUND AND RATIONALE OF THE POLICIES

A new government in Korea made small business owners its first national task (MSS, 25 August 2022, p. 1), and in the United Kingdom the Autumn Statement of 17 November reversed nearly all of the Growth Plan of September (HM Treasury, 17 November 2022, executive summary). Problem representations (Table 2) shape solutions (Bacchi, 2009) and allocate benefits (Schneider & Ingram, 1993), it has been argued.

Table 2: How the governments represented the problem

Country	Problem represented	Presupposition	Left unsaid
Korea	Owners in debt	Debt relief helps	Purchases against ratios
Japan	Guarantees deter founding	Guarantee-free loans	Disabled, older founders
China	Jobs for key groups	Small firms create jobs	Women, foreign founders
United Kingdom	Too few women founders	Voluntary investor action	Claimant founders
United States	Underserved lack capital	State credit reaches them	Disabled, older founders
France	Owners exposed to failure	Separate estates protect	Women, disabled founders
Germany	Women, migrants too few	Funds and networks help	Older, disabled founders

Source: IFEED analysis after Bacchi (2009) of the statements cited in Section 2.

3.2 THEORETICAL ANALYSIS: THEORETICAL VALIDITY AND RELEVANCE

Table 3: Theoretical validity of the main policies

Theory	Claim	Policies consistent with it	Policies in tension with it
Credit (Blanchflower & Oswald, 1998)	Lack of capital deters founders	Guaranteed loans (China); state credit (United States)	Debt relief (Korea)
Subsidies (Caliendo & Künn, 2011)	Effects last for the unemployed	Start-up grant (Germany)	Allowance closed (United Kingdom)
Failure (Armour & Cumming, 2008)	Forgiving bankruptcy law, more self-employment	Separate estates (France)	—
Immigrants (Hunt, 2011)	Study and work entrants start more firms than natives	Special zones (Japan); Innovator (United Kingdom)	Employee visa (Germany)
Women (Ahl & Nelson, 2015; Ewens & Townsend, 2020)	Investors must change	Investing in Women Code (United Kingdom)	Weeks (Korea, Japan)
Age, disability (Kautonen et al., 2014; Renko et al., 2016)	Age raises activity of the willing; disability lowers viability	Middle-aged centres (Korea)	General support (Japan)

Source: IFEED assessment of the policies reviewed in Section 2, against the sources named in the first column.

As Table 3 shows, credit meets the capital gap of founders without wealth (Blanchflower & Oswald, 1998), subsidy evidence (Caliendo & Künn, 2011) cuts against the British closure, and investor evidence (Ewens & Townsend, 2020) favours codes over weeks for women (Ahl & Nelson, 2015).

3.3 PRACTICAL ANALYSIS: PERFORMANCE, CONTRIBUTION AND IMPACT

Most measures for the smallest self-employed and for credit were in force by the end of 2022, while Germany's and Korea's instruments for women and Japan's visa route were announcements or plans (Table 4).

Table 4: Status of the main measures at the end of 2022

Country	In force or launched in 2022	Adopted, in force from 2023	Pending or announced
Korea	New Start Fund; centres; purchase ratios	Accident insurance (July 2023)	Owner definition; fund allocation; fast track
Japan	JFC loans; zone guideline; bonus points	—	Guarantee reform; visa route; freelance law; re-challenge rule (start not stated)
China	Regulation; loans; start-up space	—	Loan deferral, platform fees (requested); new urban residents (announced); small-firm procurement preferences (decided)
United Kingdom	Profits limit; Innovator change; Access to Work application; allowance closed	—	Threshold freeze; Procurement Bill; ethnicity pilot; repeal reversed
United States	State credit plans; centres; navigators	Veteran certification (January 2023)	Nonprofit lender rule (proposed); assistance (planned)
France	Act No. 2022-172; zone exemptions; Springboard	—	Rebound portal funding (no sum)
Germany	Restart aid; income support; EXIST	Citizen's income (January 2023)	Women's instruments; migrant forum; insurance

Source: IFEED compilation from the sources cited in Section 2.

Governments reported outputs, such as JFC loans (JFC, 15 November 2022, p. 1), one French cohort's survival (MEFIDS, 15 September 2022, release) and Korean purchase ratios without purchases (MSS, 24 November 2022, p. 1); Table 5 summarises Section 2. Good assessments rested on instruments in force that reached the groups, Poor ones on markets with nothing in force for them, and Mixed ones on working measures beside plans or measures for other targets.

Table 5: Assessment of the policies by domain and country

Domain	Korea	Japan	China	United Kingdom	United States	France	Germany
Regulation and Law	Mixed	Mixed	Good	Mixed	Mixed	Good	Mixed
Finance	Mixed	Mixed	Mixed	Mixed	Good	Mixed	Mixed
Culture	Mixed	Mixed	Mixed	Mixed	Mixed	Mixed	Mixed
Support	Mixed	Mixed	Mixed	Mixed	Mixed	Good	Mixed
Human Capital	Mixed	Mixed	Mixed	Mixed	Mixed	Mixed	Mixed
Market	Mixed	Mixed	Mixed	Poor	Mixed	Mixed	Poor

Source: IFEED assessment of the policies reviewed in Section 2, on the sources cited there. Where a subsection assessed its policies differently, Mixed is shown.

4 POLICY LIMITATIONS

4.1 POLICY DEBATES, CONTESTED POINTS AND ISSUES

The policies of 2022 raised five points of contention (Table 6). On the first, the question is whether relief that lowers the cost of failure encourages entry by the groups or only cushions owners already in business.

Table 6: Debates and contested points in the policies of 2022

Issue	What the governments set out	Point at issue
Cost of failure	Debt restructuring (Korea); separate estates and allowance (France); loans without guarantees (Japan) (Council for the Realisation of a New Form of Capitalism, 28 November 2022; FSC, 23 September 2022; Parliament of France, 14 February 2022)	Second chances or moral hazard
Protection of the self-employed	Accident insurance (Korea); freelance law (Japan); insurance of the self-employed (Germany) (Cabinet of Japan, 7 June 2022; Federal Government of Germany, 26 January 2022; MOEL, 29 May 2022)	Insurance or self-reliance
Targeting by group	Purchase ratios (Korea); key groups (China); underserved owners (United States); need and place (France) (General Office of the State Council of the People's Republic of China, 5 May 2022; MSS, 24 November 2022; MEFIDS, 15 September 2022; U.S. Department of the Treasury, 19 May 2022)	Group, need or place
Foreign founders	Visa plan (Japan); visa for employees (Germany); Innovator route (United Kingdom) (Council for the Realisation of a New Form of Capitalism, 28 November 2022; Federal Government of Germany, 28 July 2022; Home Office, 15 March 2022)	Migration control or founders
What to count	Loans by sex (Japan); deals with women founders (United Kingdom); ratios without purchases (Korea) (BEIS, 28 June 2022; JFC, 15 November 2022; MSS, 24 November 2022)	Outputs or reach

Source: IFEED analysis of the sources cited.

4.2 THEORETICAL LIMITATIONS OF THE POLICIES

The first limitation is that the policies counted loans, participants and approvals rather than asked what became of them, a silence, in the sense of Bacchi (2009), about whom the measures reached.

The second is a focus on groups, not institutions. Korea, Japan and Germany addressed women founders with weeks, consultations and role models, while the evidence locates part of the gap in investors (Ewens & Townsend, 2020); a policy aimed only at the group leaves unsaid the institutions that the group meets (Ahl & Nelson, 2015; Bacchi, 2009).

The third is the neglect of age and disability. Activity rises with age among those who prefer self-employment (Kautonen et al., 2014) and disabled founders less often reach a viable firm (Renko et al., 2016), yet measures for them were few and general.

5 POLICY IMPLICATIONS

First, governments should measure whom their measures reach. They should publish who applies for and receives their loans, grants and contracts by sex, age, disability and origin, as the JFC does by sex for its loans; Korea should publish purchases against its ratios, China take-up of its guaranteed loans, and the United States whom its state credit programmes reach.

Second, the self-employed should share in social insurance. Korea's accident insurance for labour providers shows a workable design; Japan should submit its freelance law and say when its re-challenge rule applies, and Germany should legislate the unemployment and old-age protection it announced.

Third, the cost of failure should be lowered for the smallest owners without closing routes into self-employment. France's separate estates and allowance and Korea's New Start Fund point the way, and Japan should bring its guarantee reform into effect as planned; the United Kingdom should replace support for claimants who start businesses, since the evidence on start-up subsidies shows the largest gains for disadvantaged founders.

Fourth, the doors for foreign founders should open as promised. Japan's guideline for special zones and the British change to the Innovator route show that small rule changes can help; Japan should open confirmation to private bodies, and Germany should give founders, not only employees, a route.

Finally, measures for women should change the institutions that women founders meet rather than their visibility alone. Asking investors to report deals by the sex of founders, as the Investing in Women Code does, funding diverse investment teams, as Germany announced, and following women's share in official statistics address the evidence; weeks alone do not. Every measure should come with a plan to evaluate its effect on the groups it names.

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